Executive Leadership Lab

Full Year Curriculum | January - December

A 12-Month Leadership Program for Women of Color

Program Overview

The Executive Leadership Lab is a 12-month leadership development program designed specifically for women of color in corporate and professional environments. Each month builds on the previous, creating a comprehensive journey from career clarity to sustainable leadership.

The Six Lanes of Development

DIRECTION

Where am I going?

VALUE

What do I contribute?

INFLUENCE

How do I move decisions?

LEADERSHIP

How do I lead others?

SUSTAINABILITY

How do I maintain energy?

RELATIONSHIPS

Who supports my growth?

The Arc of the Year

FIRST HALF: BUILDING YOUR FOUNDATION

- JANUARY **Plateaus**
- FEBRUARY **Visibility**
- MARCH **Pivot**
- APRIL **Composure**
- MAY **Advocacy**
- JUNE **Storytelling**

SUMMER PAUSE: INTEGRATION & RELATIONSHIPS

- JULY **Handouts**
- AUGUST **Handouts**

SECOND HALF: SUSTAINING YOUR LEADERSHIP

- SEPTEMBER **Leadership**
- OCTOBER **Energy**
- NOVEMBER **Confidence**
- DECEMBER **Boundaries**

JANUARY

Break Through Career Plateaus

Completed

Lane: Direction

Diagnose what's keeping you stuck and define a clear growth target for the year. Participants identify the root causes of their stagnation—whether it's visibility, skills gaps, or unclear direction—and create a tailored Career Growth Roadmap with their north-star role and 2-3 concrete goals.

Anchor Tools

- Career Growth Roadmap Worksheet
- Plateau Diagnostic
- Relationship Map (baseline)

Participant Deliverable

Clarity on what's keeping them stagnant + a tailored action plan with north-star role and 2-3 goals.

Builds into February: The roadmap defines what they need to be known for, setting up the visibility strategy work.

FEBRUARY

Strategic Positioning for Promotion

Completed

Lane: Value + Visibility Strategy

Create a visibility strategy tied to business outcomes and promotion criteria. Participants learn who the decision-makers are, build a system to track wins in real-time, and develop a plan to ensure their work is seen by the right people. This is about the *strategy* of visibility—who, when, and where.

Anchor Tools

- Visibility Strategy Checklist
- Win-Tracking Template
- Check-In Prep Template
- Performance Impact Tracker

Participant Deliverable

A clear visibility plan + a system to capture wins as proof for promotion conversations.

WOC Focus

Being seen by decision-makers when you're often overlooked. Building a sponsor pipeline of 3 internal stakeholders who should consistently see your wins.

Builds into March: Win-tracking becomes evidence for pivot stories and interviews.

MARCH

Confident Career Pivot: Own Your Next Chapter

Lane: Direction Shift + Pivot Story

For those ready to make a move, this module helps translate existing experience into a credible story for new roles. Participants build a Transferable Skills Inventory, craft a compelling pivot narrative, and prepare for the "prove it again" bias that women of color often face when changing roles. Includes informational interview strategies and application tactics.

Anchor Tools

- Transferable Skills Inventory Worksheet
- Pivot Storytelling Script Template
- Informational Interview Prep Guide
- Role-Play Prompt Cards

Participant Deliverable

A polished pivot story for interviews and networking + a list of 5 target roles/companies with an outreach plan.

WOC Focus

Overcoming the "prove it again" bias—strategies for when your experience is questioned more than others'. Owning your narrative when pivoting into new spaces.

Builds into April: Pivot conversations can trigger fear, rejection, and emotional responses. April's composure module helps manage these high-stakes moments.

APRIL

Leadership Composure: Managing Triggers, Bias & High-Stakes Moments

Lane: Influence (Internal Regulation)

Emotional regulation and leadership composure in high-stakes, often biased, environments. This module focuses on *in-the-moment* composure—what to do when you're triggered, facing a microaggression, or navigating a tense situation. Participants create a personal Trigger Map and develop rehearsed responses to common bias situations.

Key Distinction: April = Managing MOMENTS (reactive) | October = Managing ENERGY (systemic) | November = Managing MINDSET (cognitive)

Anchor Tools

- EI Self-Assessment
- Trigger Map Worksheet
- Microaggression Response Cards
- Composure Toolkit (grounding practices)
- Incident Documentation Template

Participant Deliverable

A personalized Trigger Map with response strategies + 3-5 rehearsed responses to common microaggressions.

WOC Focus

> The double bind of emotion—stereotyped as "angry" when assertive, "cold" when composed. Addresses microaggressions, the "angry Black woman" stereotype, and when to address bias immediately vs. strategically later.

Builds into May: Emotional regulation is essential for high-stakes advocacy conversations. May focuses on making the ask from a grounded place.

MAY

Advocacy & Negotiation: Promotions, Raises, Equity & Opportunities

Lane: Influence (The Ask)

The mechanics of asking for what you want—preparation, scripts, objection handling, and follow-through. Goes beyond salary to include equity, stock options, title, scope, and flexibility. Participants leave with a complete negotiation package and a scheduled conversation with their decision-maker.

Anchor Tools

- Negotiation Preparation Worksheet
- Compensation Research Guide
- Negotiation Scripts (by scenario)
- Objection Response Cards
- Meeting Plan Template
- Post-Negotiation Follow-Up Template

Participant Deliverable

A complete negotiation package: research, script, objection responses, and a scheduled advocacy conversation.

WOC Focus

The "negotiation penalty" WOC face—judged more harshly for the same behaviors. Frames negotiation as wealth-building (WOC have the largest wealth gap). Includes equity negotiation beyond just salary.

Builds into June: Once you can ask, you need a repeatable way to communicate your wins. June teaches storytelling that makes future asks easier.

JUNE

Executive Storytelling: Master Your Narrative

Lane: Value (Communicate Impact)

Turn wins into compelling stories. While February covered *strategy* (who to reach), June covers *technique* (how to say it). Participants learn story structures (STAR, CAR), craft a 2-minute Signature Story, and build a portfolio of context-specific stories for interviews, reviews, and networking.

Key Distinction: February = STRATEGY (Who, When, Where) | June = TECHNIQUE (How to say it)

Anchor Tools

- Story Structure Templates (STAR, CAR, CARL)
- Signature Story Worksheet
- Wins-to-Stories Converter
- Delivery Self-Assessment Checklist
- Board of Advisors Mapping Worksheet

Participant Deliverable

A polished 2-minute Signature Story + 3-5 context-specific stories ready for interviews, reviews, and networking.

WOC Focus

Owning your narrative without minimizing accomplishments or centering others. Claiming credit authentically.

Builds into September: Storytelling becomes a leadership communication tool for inspiring

teams and building inclusive culture.

JULY & AUGUST

Summer Integration: Relationship Building & Reflection

Lane: Relationships (Self-Paced)

No live modules during July and August. Instead, participants receive handouts for self-paced work, allowing time to integrate learning from the first half of the year while building relationships. Community engagement continues through discussion prompts and accountability partnerships.

Summer Handouts

1. Board of Advisors Deep Dive
2. Sponsor vs. Mentor Guide
3. Mid-Year Reflection Workbook
4. Networking for Introverts
5. The Reciprocity Playbook
6. Summer Reading List

Community Activities

Accountability partner pairings, weekly discussion prompts, Win of the Week threads, optional book club meetup.

Builds into September: Participants return with strengthened relationships and clarity, ready to focus on leading others.

SEPTEMBER

Inclusive Leadership: Lead Authentically & Build Your Coalition

Lane: Leadership + Culture

Lead inclusive teams while maintaining your authentic leadership style. This module addresses the unique challenges of leading as "the only" in the room, building coalition power for collective impact, and creating psychological safety when you don't feel safe yourself. Includes guidance on mentoring the next generation without burning out.

Anchor Tools

- Leadership Identity Worksheet
- Inclusive Leadership Self-Assessment
- Coalition Mapping Exercise
- Difficult Conversation Prep Template
- Support Ecosystem Blueprint

Participant Deliverable

A defined leadership identity statement, a coalition map with 3-5 allies, and a personal support ecosystem blueprint.

WOC Focus

Code-switching fatigue and finding your authentic voice. Building collective power—individual advancement has limits; coalition advocacy is powerful. Leading while "other."

Builds into October: Inclusive leadership requires sustainable energy. October focuses on

preventing burnout that often comes from leading while underrepresented.

OCTOBER

Energy Reset: Recovery Systems & Managing the Cultural Tax

Lane: Sustainability (Energy)

Burnout prevention through energy management—understanding what drains you, what fills you, and building sustainable recovery practices. This is about *systems*, not mindset reframes (November) or boundary-setting (December). Names and addresses the "cultural tax"—the invisible labor WOC carry.

Key Distinction: October = ENERGY (what drains/fills you) | December = DECISIONS (what to say yes/no to)

Anchor Tools

- Energy Audit Worksheet
- Cultural Tax Inventory
- Recovery Ritual Planner
- Stress Reset Practice Cards
- Burnout Warning Signs Checklist

Participant Deliverable

A completed Energy Audit with a personalized Recovery Plan—including daily, weekly, and monthly practices.

WOC Focus

The Cultural Tax—DEI committee work, being "the only," representing your race, emotional labor when traumatic news affects your community. Invisible labor that isn't recognized or compensated.

Builds into November: Burnout often triggers imposter spirals. October addresses energy; November addresses mindset.

NOVEMBER

Evidence-Based Confidence: From Self-Doubt to Self-Trust

Lane: Sustainability (Beliefs + Identity)

Reframe internal narratives and build self-trust using evidence—not empty affirmations, but proof-based confidence. This is *cognitive* work—changing the stories you tell yourself. Participants build an Evidence File of proof points and develop personalized affirmations grounded in actual accomplishments.

Key Distinction: April = Managing moments | October = Managing energy | November = Managing MINDSET

Anchor Tools

- Imposter Syndrome Self-Assessment
- Evidence File Template
- Reframing Worksheet
- Daily Confidence Practice Guide
- Evidence-Based Affirmations Builder

Participant Deliverable

A populated Evidence File with 10+ proof points + 5-7 personalized evidence-based affirmations.

WOC Focus

Distinguishing imposter syndrome from systemic oppression—when doubt is internal vs. when barriers are real. Building confidence while acknowledging that bias isn't imagined.

Builds into December: Stronger self-trust makes boundaries easier to set and maintain.

DECEMBER

Reclaim Your Time: Boundaries, Decisions & Your Personal Operating System

Lane: Sustainability (Systems + Standards)

Build your personal operating system for long-term success—boundaries, priorities, and decision-making frameworks. This is about *choices and systems*, not energy management (October). Participants create a Yes/No Decision Framework, develop boundary scripts, and build a 90-Day Sustainability Plan to carry their growth into the new year.

Key Distinction: October = Energy (what drains/fills you) | December = DECISIONS (what to say yes/no to)

Anchor Tools

- Boundaries Workbook
- Yes/No Decision Framework
- Boundary Scripts Library
- Calendar Audit Template
- 90-Day Sustainability Plan
- Board of Advisors Maintenance Tracker

Participant Deliverable

A complete Personal Operating System: boundaries defined, decision framework created, calendar protected, and a 90-day plan for sustaining growth.

WOC Focus

Permission to protect your time when socialized to be accommodating. Setting limits without damaging relationships or reputation.

Program Closing: December includes celebration of wins from the year, reinforcing key tools, and setting intentions for continued growth. Consider a final recognition ceremony.

Quick Reference: All Sessions

Month	Session Title	Lane	Anchor Tool
JAN	Break Through Career Plateaus	Direction	Career Growth Roadmap
FEB	Strategic Positioning for Promotion	Value	Visibility Strategy Checklist
MAR	Confident Career Pivot: Own Your Next Chapter	Direction	Transferable Skills Inventory
APR	Leadership Composure: Managing Triggers, Bias & High-Stakes Moments	Influence	Trigger Map + Response Cards
MAY	Advocacy & Negotiation: Promotions, Raises, Equity & Opportunities	Influence	Negotiation Scripts
JUN	Executive Storytelling: Master Your Narrative	Value	Signature Story Worksheet
JUL-AUG	Summer Integration (Handouts Only)	Relationships	Board of Advisors Deep Dive
SEP	Inclusive Leadership: Lead Authentically & Build Your Coalition	Leadership	Leadership Identity + Coalition Map
OCT	Energy Reset: Recovery Systems & Managing the Cultural Tax	Sustainability	Energy Audit + Cultural Tax Inventory
NOV	Evidence-Based Confidence: From Self-Doubt to Self-Trust	Sustainability	Evidence File Template

Month	Session Title	Lane	Anchor Tool
DEC	Reclaim Your Time: Boundaries, Decisions & Your Personal Operating System	Sustainability	Boundaries Workbook + 90-Day Plan